Inspection of West Sussex local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 14 to 25 September 2026

Lead inspector: Michael Taylor, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	**Grade**
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Good
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Good
The experiences and progress of children in care	Good
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Good

Senior leaders in West Sussex have a clear overview of the quality of children's services, where improvements have been made and where further work is required. Senior leaders demonstrate clear ambition for children and families and have maintained a strong focus on sustaining improvement and building on progress. There have been significant improvements in how children are helped and protected and the quality of support available for care leavers. A stable workforce, continued investment and strong partnership working provide a firm foundation for sustaining these improvements.

Leaders recognise that there is more to do, particularly to improve transitions to adulthood for some children and increase the sufficiency and choice of homes for children in care and care leavers. They are committed to further improvement and have developed plans to address these areas, although some of this work is recent and the impact on children is not yet fully evident.

What needs to improve?[1]

- The sufficiency and choice of suitable homes for children in care. (outcome 4: national framework)
- The timeliness and effectiveness of transition planning for children approaching adulthood, including disabled children and children moving to leaving care services. (outcome 4: national framework)
- The consistent exploration and understanding of children and young people's culture and heritage and their journeys before coming into care. (outcome 4: national framework)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: good

1. Children and their families receive timely and appropriate help and support at the earliest opportunity. Targeted family support is well informed by practitioners' thorough understanding of children's and families' needs. Families are directed to a wide range of services designed to meet their needs. When needs escalate or situations do not improve, there are clear and considered processes to seamlessly escalate to other levels of support and intervention.

2. The 'dedicated schools' team is a strength. Family support workers provide essential support, advice and guidance to schools, enabling support to be provided to families at the earliest opportunity and reducing the need to escalate to higher levels of support and intervention.

3. When children and families are referred to the 'integrated front door', they receive a proportionate and timely response. Managers provide detailed direction, enabling social workers to progress enquiries effectively and resulting in families receiving the right support at the right time.

4. When safeguarding concerns are highlighted, strategy meetings are timely and proportionate to risk and children's needs. Effective multi-agency information-sharing and analysis result in clear actions to safeguard children. Child protection enquiries thoroughly explore concerns and conclude with timely, clear analysis and decisions that safeguard children.

5. Most children benefit from thorough holistic assessments of their needs, which are influenced by their voice. Their views are gathered through age-appropriate and child-focused direct work. Children's individual needs and experiences are well understood; however, for a small group of children, further improvements

[1] The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the Children's Social Care: National Framework. This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

could be made to explore their cultural identity and heritage to ensure a thorough understanding of how this affects their needs.

6. Assessments of expectant parents are effective and commence early, supporting thorough consideration of need and risk. This supports informed, appropriate planning and intervention and assists parents to understand what is needed and required of them.

7. Children who are victims of domestic abuse receive a prompt and appropriate response. Risks are well assessed and informed by multi-agency information and specialist domestic abuse expertise. Families receive specialist support when needed, with practitioners considering their ongoing needs throughout.

8. The emergency duty service responds effectively when concerns about children arise outside of office hours. Children and families receive a proportionate and timely response to safeguarding concerns, with effective handovers to daytime services.

9. Children's plans are purposeful and provide clarity to parents and carers regarding what is needed to improve children's experiences. Plans are well informed by children's voices and are regularly reviewed and updated with families and partner agencies, enabling progress and ongoing risks to be considered. Family network meetings are utilised well to inform plans. When neglect is a concern, assessments and plans help practitioners understand its current and historical impact on children and respond to their needs.

10. Most disabled children who are subject to child protection plans make positive progress. Disabled children who are supported by child in need plans benefit from practitioners who know them well and who build positive relationships and understand their individual needs.

11. When progress is not being achieved and concerns for children persist, there is timely consideration of escalation and the pre-proceedings stage of the Public Law Outline. Decisions are clearly reasoned, with actions and timescales identified to support timely progress. Most letters before proceedings clearly outline the changes required, helping parents to understand what they need to do to improve outcomes for their children.

12. Most children benefit from appropriate assessments and interventions during pre-proceedings, which progress without unnecessary delay. As a result of interventions, children and families have been successfully diverted from legal proceedings when sufficient progress has been made.

13. The local authority designated officer provides an effective response to allegations about professionals. Referrals are appropriately considered, with clear and timely decisions about the actions needed to safeguard children.

14. Children and young people at risk of exploitation benefit from comprehensive assessments that identify risks and inform actions to reduce harm. Multi-agency oversight supports effective planning for children when risks are escalating. Serious youth violence workers are tenacious and child focused. They understand children and young people's trauma and vulnerabilities, as well as their individual strengths and aspirations, helping them to build relationships and respond to children's needs.

15. There is an effective response to children who go missing from home. Return home interviews help practitioners understand children's experiences, the reasons they go missing and the risks they face, informing ongoing safety planning and support.

16. Young carers are identified and receive effective support. They benefit from a range of help, including therapeutic and respite support. There are opportunities to spend time with other young carers, helping them to develop supportive relationships and have time for themselves.

17. Children aged 16 or 17 who are at risk of homelessness benefit from effective joint working between children's services, housing and specialist homelessness practitioners. Assessments are comprehensive and consider children's circumstances and views, resulting in clear plans. This helps children to remain safely at home where appropriate or secure suitable alternative accommodation.

18. Carers of children who are privately fostered receive thorough and timely assessments and reviews, with all relevant checks undertaken. The private fostering team has an effective communication strategy to raise awareness through community engagement events.

19. Many children who are electively home educated benefit from effective systems to oversee and monitor the arrangements, ensuring that any concerns that emerge are responded to. While no children were identified as being at risk, the oversight of these arrangements is not sufficiently effective for some children who are missing education. Leaders have recognised this weakness and have started to strengthen their oversight. These changes have recently been implemented, and it is too early to see their full impact.

The experiences and progress of children in care: good

20. Decision-making for children to come into care is proportionate to identified risk, and most children come into care at the right time.

21. When children cannot safely remain with their parents, there is routine and robust exploration of their wider family network and potential carers, helping children remain with their families. Family network meetings involve parents, carers and others who are important to children, helping families to contribute

meaningfully to planning for their care. Assessments of potential kinship carers are thorough and carried out promptly.

22. Most children's plans are reviewed regularly and effectively and are informed by children's views. Children who choose to attend their reviews share their views, while others choose to speak with their advocates, ensuring that their voice is heard. Conference and reviewing officers write sensitively worded letters that help children understand their progress and key decisions made. Reviews and plans are well informed by detailed and thorough assessments of needs that reflect their experiences and progress.

23. Children placed with their parents receive sufficient oversight and support through regular visits and reviews. Frequent and timely management oversight, alongside detailed assessments, supports safe planning for these children.

24. Planning for children with a plan of special guardianship is timely, with purposeful assessment of children's and prospective carers' needs. Where reunification is considered, parents are appropriately assessed, and children's return home is carefully planned. Children who leave care do so following effective planning and decision-making.

25. Social workers build trusting and reliable relationships with children. This enables children to talk about issues that matter to them, including difficult and traumatic experiences. Children are seen regularly and in line with their assessed needs. Thoughtful and creative direct work helps children, including disabled children with communication needs, to express their views and understand their experiences in care.

26. The Children in Care Council is a lively and impactful group of individuals who meet regularly. Children benefit from engaging in activities and contributing to some key projects they feel support other children when they enter care. An example of this is the 'blanket that cares'**,** designed by children to provide comfort and reassurance to other children entering care**.** They are actively engaged in the corporate parenting panel and have influenced some key decisions that have been made regarding improving services for children in care.

27. Children access helpful and insightful life-story work when it is right for them. This supports them to make sense of their histories and better understand their experiences and journeys into care.

28. Children in care who are vulnerable to exploitation benefit from effective support and multi-agency planning, which facilitates information-sharing and action to reduce risk. When children go missing, return home interviews help practitioners understand their experiences and reassess risks when necessary.

29. Children's physical and emotional health needs are regularly assessed and reviewed. Children benefit from a range of therapeutic and mental health support services, including the support offered by the 'attach and restore' team.

30. Disabled children are supported by skilled and knowledgeable practitioners who know them well and understand their needs and communication styles. This translates into effective and clear plans that meet needs.

31. Unaccompanied asylum-seeking children benefit from practitioners who build positive relationships with them and develop a clear understanding of their individual needs. Most plans are detailed and consider the needs of unaccompanied asylum-seeking children. However, for a few children, their plans do not thoroughly explore their experiences of trauma, their journeys to the UK and the impact of adjusting to a new culture.

32. The virtual school has a strong understanding of children's educational needs and how trauma can affect their development. It routinely analyses children's progress and intervenes when children are at risk of not achieving as expected with their education. Leaders know more is needed to improve some children's attendance in education.

33. Permanence planning is purposeful and provides effective oversight of children's plans. Most children live in stable homes that meet their needs, and they flourish. A small group of children experience changes in their home. They benefit from the oversight and focus provided through permanence planning forums. They utilise learning and identify placements that are better able to meet children's needs, which promotes more stable homes for children.

34. Family relationships and family time are carefully considered and planned around children's individual needs. Social workers maintain a strong focus on sustaining relationships that are important to children, including positive relationships with brothers and sisters and parents.

35. Several children aged 12 and under live in children's homes because suitable foster carers who could meet their needs have not been available. These children are well supported and regularly visited, and their needs are being met. Their care plans explore their needs and identify how these needs will be met. Regular reviews provide additional oversight, ensuring that these homes continue to be the most appropriate settings for these children. Older children living in children's homes are seen regularly by social workers who advocate strongly for them and work effectively with partner agencies to ensure that their needs are understood and supported.

36. Children aged 16 and 17 move into supported accommodation following a thorough assessment of their readiness and needs. They receive support that helps them engage in education or training and develop the skills they need for greater independence.

37. A small and decreasing number of children are living in unlawful unregistered children's homes. For most children, there is appropriate oversight and scrutiny by social workers and senior leaders while registered provision is sought. For a very small number of children in health-based settings, a misunderstanding about the registration status of the setting has resulted in the children not having a similar level of oversight. While no safeguarding concerns were identified, this misunderstanding has resulted in senior leaders' oversight not being as robust.

38. Most children placed at a distance from the local authority benefit from social workers who know them well and maintain consistent relationships with them. This helps social workers understand children's experiences and provide support that responds to their changing needs.

39. Children in long-term foster homes benefit from being seen regularly and having positive relationships with social workers who understand their views and feelings. Children experience a strong sense of belonging in their foster families and are supported to enjoy family life and benefit from enduring relationships with their carers.

40. Foster carers benefit from effective assessment, training and support that help them to meet children's needs. Supervising social workers know carers and children well. Recruitment activity increasingly focuses on developing a more diverse pool of carers who can meet children's differing needs.

41. Adoption arrangements are effective and focus on securing the right families for children without unnecessary delay. Assessments are timely and thorough, giving adopters a clear understanding of children's histories, experiences and future needs. Effective panel scrutiny supports timely and well-reasoned decisions about children's permanence. Adopters are well prepared through training and benefit from responsive, bespoke adoption support as children's and families' needs change.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: good

42. Care leavers in West Sussex benefit from services that have significantly improved since the inspection in 2023. They have access to an improved and enhanced local offer, improved housing options and more responsive support for those aged 21 and over.

43. Care leavers benefit from reliable and positive relationships with their personal advisers (PAs), who know them well and visit them in line with their needs and wishes. Visits are purposeful, and PAs maintain an up-to-date understanding of care leavers' needs. PAs advocate strongly for care leavers when they need specialist support.

44. Care leavers are well supported by their social workers until they transition to leaving care services. Not all care leavers fully benefit from having the opportunity to build a trusting relationship with their PA before they leave care. Senior leaders have recruited additional PAs to meet demand but currently not all care leavers are benefiting from this. Some care leavers experience changes in PA, which can further disrupt the development of these relationships. Transition planning for disabled children approaching adulthood does not always start early enough. Some arrangements for children are not always established in sufficient time to prepare them and their families for where they will live and how their care needs will be met.

45. Most care leavers benefit from comprehensive assessments that identify their needs and inform clear pathway plans to support their independence, health and relationships. Their cultural needs are well understood and inform the support and accommodation they receive. Pathway plans are warmly written and developed with care leavers, helping them to understand and take ownership of their plans. Plans are regularly reviewed and updated when young people's circumstances change.

46. Care leavers access a comprehensive local offer that provides clarity about their entitlements and financial and practical support as they move towards independence. PAs support care leavers to access important documents and ensure they receive their entitlements. PAs are alert to the potential for loneliness and isolation among care leavers. They help young people to build supportive social networks and access mental health and therapeutic support when needed.

47. The West Sussex Care Leavers Advisory Board is an active and effective group for care-experienced young people. They have accomplished many significant achievements to improve the experience of care-experienced young people in West Sussex and are ambitious to continue to raise awareness and bring about wider improvement. They play a key part in enabling the council to ensure strategies, policies and key decisions have input from care-experienced people.

48. Care leavers are provided with coordinated support to pursue their education, employment and training ambitions. PAs and partner agencies help young people develop employability skills and access opportunities that reflect their aspirations, abilities and interests. Practical support also helps care leavers to develop the skills and confidence they need for independence and adulthood.

49. Care leavers aged 21 and over explore with their PAs their needs and the level of support they feel is needed as they continue into adulthood. Care leavers who do not require intensive support have easier access to the leaving care service through a more effective duty response, providing timely help when needed while promoting their independence. PAs maintain contact with older care leavers so that they can readily access support when they need or want it.

50. Care leavers benefit from effective housing support and accommodation that reflects their needs and wishes. They are well supported to prepare for independent living and with the practicalities of setting up their own homes. Some care leavers have to wait for permanent tenancies due to high demand for properties in their preferred areas. Care leavers are encouraged and supported to save for deposits and work towards gaining and securing their own homes through tenancies and mortgages.

51. Care leavers who are parents are well supported by sensitive and caring PAs who know and understand them well. Emotional and practical support is provided at a pace that reflects their individual needs. PAs support care leavers through pregnancy and in preparing for parenthood, including helping them to attend health appointments and access services that enable them to build supportive networks. This helps care leavers to feel supported as they adjust to their responsibilities as parents.

52. Care leavers in custody receive help and guidance that is responsive to their individual needs. Pathway plans reflect their changing circumstances and PAs are in regular contact and encourage care leavers to reflect on their circumstances and aspirations for their future, helping them to know that they continue to matter and are cared about.

53. Care leavers who have sought asylum receive effective and culturally sensitive support. PAs build reliable relationships and develop a thorough understanding of their current and previous experiences, including trauma. They understand care leavers' cultural and religious needs and support them to navigate immigration processes. Many care leavers are well supported to make strong progress, including in education and employment.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: good

54. Corporate and senior leaders articulate a consistent vision and strong commitment to sustaining improvement and improving outcomes for children and families in West Sussex. This commitment is demonstrated through continued investment, despite financial pressures and uncertainty linked to potential local government reorganisation. They are collectively focused and clear that transformation and creation of effective services is central to achieving longer-term sustainability and impact for West Sussex children.

55. Political leaders share a clear vision for improving children's services and work collaboratively with senior leaders and partners to drive continued improvement. Strong governance arrangements, together with effective independent scrutiny and a well-developed safeguarding partnership, provide appropriate challenge and support improvements in services for children and families.

56. Senior leaders have identified areas where practice has been less consistent and have taken effective action to strengthen services. Further investment in services for children in care, care leavers, the virtual school and commissioning is beginning to have a positive impact, with improving practice contributing to better experiences for children and families.

57. There is a strong collective commitment to corporate parenting across all levels of the council, with an influential corporate parenting panel co-chaired by elected members, children and young people.

58. Leaders ensure that children and care-experienced young people have meaningful opportunities to influence services. The Children in Care Council and Care Leavers Advisory Board are active and influential, enabling children and young people to use their experiences to shape service development and decision-making. Their views inform strategies, policies and practical improvements, demonstrating that leaders listen and respond to what children and care-experienced young people tell them.

59. Long-term strategic investment in services for children in care is increasing fostering capacity and reducing the use of unregistered placements. Investment in fostering hubs, in-house children's homes and 'the children's home collaborative' is supporting the development and sufficiency of a range of local homes. However, the impact of this has not yet been felt in full, meaning that there is still an over-reliance on residential placements for younger children.

60. There has been a positive decline in the use of unregistered provision over recent months. Leaders recognise that further work is needed to strengthen their approach and ensure they have sufficient choice of suitable homes to meet children's needs and increasing demand.

61. There has been a significant increase in the numbers of unaccompanied asylum-seeking children in West Sussex. Senior leaders have been rightly sighted on the needs of this group of children and have developed and invested in services to meet these children's needs. Leaders understand the challenges they face in sustaining services to meet this group's needs and continue to work with others to ensure that there is sufficient capacity and funding to develop these services further.

62. Leaders recognise the need for better coordination and support across council services to ensure children receive timely and purposeful preparation for transition to adulthood. Plans and actions are under way to improve and strengthen arrangements, but it is too early to see the impact on children.

63. Partnership arrangements in West Sussex have improved, and they continue to develop further. There has been some positive improvement in services to meet needs, including services to support suicide prevention and the development of

the 'Horizon' team. This is one example of how partners have responded to learning from a rapid review.

64. There is a strong organisational learning culture in West Sussex, supported by a robust quality assurance framework. Substantial audit activity, extensive moderation and effective performance reporting provide leaders with a clear understanding of practice. Quality assurance is reflective as well as compliance focused, demonstrating leaders' ambition to understand the quality and impact of practice and use learning to drive improvement.

65. Leaders have invested in developing a whole-service understanding of culturally competent practice, which is being embedded across the service. This is not yet seen consistently in every aspect of the service and senior leaders know more is needed to do this.

66. Workers in West Sussex speak positively about the support they receive from their managers. Regular supervision, protected learning opportunities and support to develop their practice help workers feel valued and supported, providing a strong foundation for workforce development and retention.

67. A particular strength is the stable and mostly permanent workforce, with low staff turnover and reduced reliance on agency staff. Leaders invest in developing their own workforce, with strong support for newly qualified social workers and opportunities for staff to develop and progress within the organisation.

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